Aquifer Open Study Notes

This work is an adaptation of Tyndale Open Study Notes © 2023 Tyndale House Publishers, licensed under the CC BY-SA 4.0 license. The adaptation, Aquifer Open Study Notes, was created by Mission Mutual and is also licensed under CC BY-SA 4.0.

This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Judges

Judges 1:1

The request for divine guidance (see Exodus 28:30; Numbers 27:21; 1 Samuel 14:41; 28:6; compare Joshua 7:14) reminds us that the Lord's covenant with Israel included taking the land.

Judges 1:1–2.5

The first prologue talks about how the tribes did not follow Joshua's farewell instructions (Joshua 23).

Judges 1:1–3.6

Two introductions (Judges 1:1–2:5 and 2:6–3:6) come before the main part of the book. Both start with Joshua's death (Judges 1:1; see also 2:8), linking Judges to the earlier story (Joshua 24:29–33; compare Joshua 1:1; 2 Samuel 1:1).

Judges 1:2

This verse, also found in the epilogues (Judges 20:18), highlights Judah's importance. This tribe did not participate in the judges' decline (compare Judges 15:9–13) after Othniel, the ideal judge connected to Judah through Caleb (Joshua 14:6; 15:13, 17).

Judges 1:3

- The tribe of Simeon almost vanished within the territory given to Judah (Joshua 19:1).
- fight against the Canaanites…go with you to your territory: See Joshua 16:10; 17:13; 23:4–13.

Judges 1:10

Hebron was the city closest to Abraham's home by the oaks of Mamre (Genesis 13:18). The patriarchs later lived and were buried there (Genesis 23:19; 35:27; 49:29–32). It was originally called Kiriath-arba, meaning "City of Arba," named after the legendary Arba, who was a great hero of the descendants of Anak and Anak's ancestor (Joshua 14:15; 15:13). The Anakites are identified with the feared Nephilites (Numbers 13:33; see Genesis 6:4).

Judges 1:11

Debir (formerly known as Kiriath-sepher) (literally City of the Book): This was a major Anakite town in the hill country (Joshua 11:21). Its exact location is uncertain, but it is traditionally thought to be either southwest or east of Hebron.

Judges 1:14

urged him: See study note on Joshua 15:18–19.

Judges 1:16

The Kenites were a desert people who lived in the southern region. They were connected to the family of Moses by marriage and were also called Midianites (Exodus 18:1; Numbers 10:29). Moses invited them to share in the covenant blessing (God's promised favor and protection) given to Israel (Numbers 10:29–32).

At least one Kenite clan accepted this invitation and became part of the tribe of Judah. Later, however, some members of this clan changed their loyalty and supported Jabin of Hazor, an enemy king (Judges 4:11, 17).

Judges 1:17

- devoted the city to destruction: See Leviticus 27:28–29.
- Hormah: See study note on Numbers 21:2–3.

Judges 1:18

Gaza, Ashkelon, and Ekron, along with Gath and Ashdod, later became the five main cities of the Philistines (Judges 3:3).

Judges 1:19–20

Even with the Lord's presence, they did not finish the conquest due to iron chariots and disobedience (see Joshua 23:12–13; 24:14).

Judges 1:21

- The tribe of Benjamin produced many heroes, like Ehud and Saul, but it also showed great unfaithfulness to the covenant, unlike Judah (see Judges 20:18). Like Judah in its first battle (Judges 1:4–8), Benjamin faced strong people in a large city but chose to share the city with them. There is no mention of the Lord's presence (compare Judges 1:19, 22). The Jebusite city stayed under Canaanite control until David's time.
- The phrase "to this day" highlights either ongoing historical situations (here and Judges 6:24) or the continuation of certain customs to a later time (1:26; 10:4; 15:19; 18:12).

Judges 1:21–36

The tribes of Israel did not keep the covenant. Their complacency was rebellion against the Lord, as shown in the rest of the book of Judges.

Judges 1:22

- The Lord supported the descendants of Joseph (the tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh) only when they attacked Bethel together. Bethel was a sacred place for the Israelites since Jacob's time (Genesis 28:19). They failed when they attacked separately (Judges 1:27–29).
- Bethel is linked to the battle against Ai (Joshua 7:2) and is mentioned in the list of kings that Israel defeated (Joshua 12:16).

Judges 1:22–36

Mentions of Joseph's descendants (Judges 1:22, 35) highlight the northern tribes' failures to remove their enemies.

Judges 1:24

To show mercy (Hebrew khesed) suggests making a covenant (See also Judges 8:35, "kindness").

Judges 1:26

The land of the Hittites likely referred to North Syria, not the Hittite Kingdom in Anatolia (modern-day Turkey). We know nothing about the new Luz.

Judges 1:27

This group of Canaanite cities extended from Dor on the Mediterranean to Beth-shan in the Jordan Valley. It effectively separated the northern tribes from those south of the Jezreel Valley. Similarly, several cities listed in the south (Judges 1:35) likely separated Judah from the northern tribes.

Judges 1:34

Dan's failure to take the land shows complete unfaithfulness and led to abandoning part of the promised land (Judges 17–18).

Judges 2:1

Even when Israel was unfaithful, God's promise to Abraham stayed unconditional (Genesis 12:1–3; 17:1–22; compare 2 Timothy 2:13).

Judges 2:1–5

The sanctuary was established at Gilgal (Joshua 4:19û20; 5:10). Bokim is an unknown location where an angel of the Lord made an announcement. This announcement caused weeping and an attempt to reverse the judgment by offering a sacrifice.

Judges 2:2

The gods of other nations were not neutral. Destroying pagan altars was essential for following the covenant. Failing to do so would lead to social and religious compromise, and the people of the land would oppress Israel (see Deuteronomy 20:17–18).

Judges 2:6–3.6

The second prologue continues from the events of Joshua 23–24 (see study note on Judges 1:1–3:6). It introduces a third generation (Judges 2:10) who did not personally witness the Lord's mighty acts.

Judges 2:8

Compare Judges 1:1; Joshua 24:29–31.

Judges 2:10–19

Joshua had died, and the new generation had not seen God's saving power. The Canaanites still lived in the land. This led to a cycle of rebellion and partial restoration. This section introduces that cycle, which the main part of the book shows.

Judges 2:11–13

- Israel turned away from the Lord and started worshiping the gods of nearby nations, especially the Canaanite gods Baal and Asherah.
- Baal means "lord"; Ashtoreth may be a Hebrew version of the Canaanite goddess "Astarte," who had different forms. See also Judges 6:25–32 and Judges 6:25–32.

Judges 2:14–15

When Israel worshipped other gods, God withdrew his support. Their rebellion led to military defeat and great distress from their enemies.

Judges 2:15

God was not just absent; he played an active role in Israel's defeat. The Lord determined the battle's outcome (see 2 Chronicles 20:15).

Judges 2:16–19

The Lord appointed judges who led to some temporary recovery. People later described them as "judging" Israel (for example, Judges 3:10; 4:4; 10:2–3), but they were mainly famous for their military successes.

Judges 2:20–23

The remaining Canaanites and their religion tempted the Israelites, offering an alternative to following the

Lord and his covenant. God knew and even planned this outcome (compare Judges 3:4), but he does not set his people up to sin (James 1:12–15). Temptations are everywhere, but the choice to obey God or give in to temptation is up to those who claim to know him. Israel had a duty to fully possess the land, but God, not humans, decides victory or failure.

Judges 3:1–4

The Philistines and Canaanites stayed in the land to teach important lessons. People needed warfare skills to survive in ancient times. God let these enemies stay to train and help Israel.

Judges 3:3

- The Philistines were not listed with the native Canaanite tribes. They were sea invaders who settled on Israel's southwest coast around 1200 BC. The Philistines had five cities, each with its own ruler (see 1 Samuel 6:16–17). They are mentioned with the Canaanites because they became Israel's main enemy from Samson's time onward.
- The text includes Sidonians and northern Hivites to show that Israel's ideal borders were far north and east of what they actually controlled.
- The Hivites were Canaanite (Hamitic) people (Genesis 10:17). Little is known about them. The Gibeonites, who tricked Joshua (Joshua 9:3–27), were Hivites.
- Baal-hermon is possibly the largest of the three peaks of Mount Hermon in Israel's northeast corner. Lebo-hamath, in southern Lebanon, marks Israel's northernmost ideal boundary (1 Kings 8:65).

Judges 3:5–6

Israel did not pass God's test (Judges 3:1–4). Marrying people from other groups led Israel to worship the fertility gods of the Canaanites.

Judges 3:7–11

The story of Othniel is a typical example of the cycles in Judges. People did wrong, often worshipping Baal and Asherah (see study notes on Judges 2:11–13; 6:25–32). This angered the Lord and led to foreign oppression. The people's cries moved God to show compassion and send a rescuer-judge through his spirit. The rescuer stopped the oppression, and the land experienced peace before the cycle repeated. Othniel represents an ideal judge.

Judges 3:8

- Cushan-rishathaim means "Cushan of Double Wickedness."
- Aram-naharaim means "Aram of the Two Rivers." This name likely refers to the area between the Euphrates and Balih Rivers in Mesopotamia. It may also mean Mesopotamia, which translates to "Midst of the Two Rivers," the area between the Tigris and the Euphrates.

Judges 3:12–13

- The people of Moab and the Ammonites descended from Lot's relationship with his daughters (Genesis 19:30–38). Although related to Israel, both nations were Israel's enemies.
- The Amalekites were nomads who attacked Israel in the desert, and Israel was commanded to remain hostile toward them (Numbers 24:20; Deuteronomy 25:17–19). These three nations likely joined forces because they feared Israel's expansion.

Judges 3:12–30

In this epic story of intrigue and cleverness, Ehud showed bravery when a group of nations from east of the Jordan invaded the hill country of Ephraim and Benjamin. The story uses a familiar pattern and emphasizes the people's repeated turning away from their faith.

Judges 3:15

- left-handed (literally restricted in the right hand): This trait allowed Ehud to hide his weapon on his right hip. The Greek Old Testament translates this phrase as "ambidextrous." The term is linked to the tribe of Benjamin ("son of my right hand," Genesis 35:18; see Judges 20:16) and is associated with heroic military skills (compare 1 Chronicles 12:1–2).
- The tribute money was either pieces of metal or, more likely, agricultural goods that needed a team of bearers (Judges 3:18).

Judges 3:16

A knife for cutting has a single blade. This double-edged dagger is designed to easily stab a victim.

Judges 3:19

Gilgal became the Israelites' first base after they crossed the Jordan River. It was the site of key events during their conquest (Joshua 4–6). The stone idols might have been a pagan shrine made from the twelve stones Joshua set up (Joshua 4:20). Later, Gilgal remained an important center for both the faithful

(1 Samuel 7:16) and idol worshippers (Hosea 4:15; 9:15; 12:11; Amos 4:4; 5:5).

Judges 3:19–21

The message needed to be secret so Ehud could be alone with the king. It had to be from God to make sure the plan worked. Eglon likely stood up because he expected a message from the Lord, which he did receive.

Judges 3:20

The cool upstairs room was likely a rooftop chamber, often used for summer meetings in hot countries.

Judges 3:23

went out through the porch: The latrine (porch) might have been like those in medieval Europe. It was common for a latrine to extend from a building wall, with an external chute similar to today's laundry or chimney ash chutes.

Judges 3:24–25

As the king's servants hesitated over how to handle a king with bowel issues, Ehud made his escape.

Judges 3:26

Seirah is not well-known, but it was reachable from the hill country. Ephraim and Benjamin could gather there.

Judges 3:27–28

blew the ram's horn: The trumpet sound and the call "Follow me" came with a promise of victory from God through the chosen rescuer.

Judges 3:31

- Shamgar is not specifically identified as an Israelite or a judge (see Judges 5:6–7).
- Son of Anath: Anath might have been a Canaanite goddess or shrine (compare Judges 1:33, "Beth-anath"). Some ancient texts suggest he was part of a Canaanite warrior class.

Judges 4:1

The start of Judges 4 connects to Ehud and highlights the repeating cycle of Israel's experiences during this time.

Judges 4:1–5.31

The story of Deborah and Barak, found in both prose (Judges 4) and poetry (Judges 5), describes a major military operation against a significant Canaanite enemy after the initial conquest. Another king named Jabin, who also ruled in Hazor, was defeated earlier by Joshua along with a large northern alliance, and Hazor was burned (see Joshua 11:1–15). Although Joshua 11 and Judges 4–5 are often compared, they have too many differences to be considered accounts of the same battle. Instead, Jabin is likely a dynastic name; it appears in the Mari texts for an even earlier king of Hazor, around 1800 BC.

Judges 4:2

- Hazor, located north of the Sea of Galilee, controlled major trade routes running north-south and east-west. Ancient Near Eastern documents often mention Hazor, and archaeologists have extensively excavated the site. History and archaeology confirm its role as a former "the head of all these kingdoms" (Joshua 11:10).
- Harosheth-hagoyim (literally "Forest or Farmland of the Nations") might have been a staging area for the battle; its location and history are debated.

Judges 4:3

Historical records show that armies like Sisera's had many iron chariots. They expected to easily defeat the lightly armed Israelite foot soldiers.

Judges 4:4–7

Deborah was a prophet (Hebrew 'ishah nebi'a, meaning a female prophet), who served as a judge (shoptah, a feminine verb; see study note on Judges 2:16–19). She is the main character in this story, although much of the action involves her assistant, Barak. Unlike most characters in the book of Judges, Deborah acted as both a judge and a military leader. As a prophet, she predicted Samuel's later work (1 Samuel 7:15–17). Deborah called for a holy war where the Lord would fight for his people (Judges 4:6–7; see study notes on Deuteronomy 1:30; 2 Chronicles 20:20–21).

Judges 4:6

- Although Barak is listed as an Israelite hero (Hebrews 11:32), the Book of Judges gives him equal status with Deborah.
- Mount Tabor was in Issachar's territory, just north of the Jezreel Valley.

Judges 4:7

The Kishon River flows northwest into the Mediterranean Sea, just north of Mount Carmel, and shaped the Jezreel Valley.

Judges 4:8

The theme of the hesitant hero appears again with Gideon (Judges 6:15; compare Exodus 3:11).

Judges 4:9

- A woman would receive the honor for the victory, causing Barak to lose face.
- This Kedesh seems to have been near Mount Tabor (compare Judges 4:6, 12), a different location from the Kedesh in Naphtali (4:6), which was too far north for the described action.

Judges 4:10

The warriors were from Barak's tribe, Naphtali, and its southern neighbor, Zebulun.

Judges 4:11

The Kenites were related to the family of Moses by marriage. They had settled in Judah (Judges 1:16), in the southern desert (Exodus 2:16–22). They settled near the Amalekites in the mountains close to Moab (Numbers 24:21–22). Part of the tribe had apparently moved north and settled near the Sea of Galilee.

Judges 4:12–13

When Barak gathered his troops, Sisera walked into the Lord's trap. He led his chariots to the Jezreel Valley, moving along the Kishon River where wheeled vehicles could move easily.

Judges 4:14–16

- Mount Tabor, covered in forest, was a strategic location. The sudden charge down the hill likely surprised the unsuspecting Canaanites. The battle was won because it was the Lord's war, not due to human strategy or tactics.
- The text does not explain why the chariots were ineffective; this is detailed in the poetic version of the account (Judges 5:21).

Judges 4:17–20

Sisera believed he was among friends (see Judges 4:11). A woman whose husband was away would typically invite a man into her tent only for intimate reasons. However, Sisera saw this invitation as a chance for safety. Jael did not disturb his trust as she hid and refreshed him.

Judges 4:19

The milk was likely the curds that the Arabs favored (compare "curds," Judges 5:25). Many believe it causes sleepiness.

Judges 4:21–22

Jael achieved what she intended from the start. A more detailed description of the event is in Judges 5:26–27.

Judges 4:23

God defeated Jabin by guiding people and events.

Judges 4:24

Sisera's army was defeated, but Jabin and his kingdom were weakened over time.

Judges 5:1–31

This song, a victory hymn usually credited to Deborah, offers a poetic version of the battle, adding details to the prose account. It is one of the oldest Hebrew poems. It praises the Lord, the tribes who joined the fight, and Jael. It curses those who stayed home, Sisera, and his mother's followers. It contrasts life before Barak's victory, when the Lord's curse was on the land, with the blessings after the warriors' righteous acts. It ends with a prayer that the Lord's enemies will perish like Sisera (Judges 5:31).

Judges 5:3

The victory song is mainly a hymn to the Lord, the God of Israel. It is also a wisdom song that offers guidance to kings and rulers, similar to other wisdom psalms (see "Wisdom Psalms" Theme Note).

Judges 5:4–5

- In the poem, the Lord marches from his home in the mountains of Edom (compare Habakkuk 3:3) or Mount Sinai. One tradition places Sinai east of the Jordan Valley, in Edom (compare Galatians 4:25). The fire and earthquake that terrified Israel during the giving of the law (see Exodus 19:18) symbolize God's power and anger on the battlefield against his enemies.
- Torrential rain would have turned the ground into mud, making Sisera's chariots a problem instead of an advantage (see Judges 4:15–16).

Judges 5:6

During this chaotic and uncertain time, people outside the main walled cities had little security. Even Sham-

gar (see Judges 3:31) did not ease the suffering of common people. They endured hardships under the Canaanites and their cruel commander, Sisera.

Judges 5:7

Deborah was God's agent in bringing relief during a widespread social breakdown. She did not gather or lead the troops, but she was Israel's spiritual and emotional support. She is described as a mother in Israel.

Judges 5:8

- Israel was in social chaos and lacked defensive weapons.
- forty thousand: The Hebrew word translated as thousand could also mean clans (see study note on Exodus 12:37).

Judges 5:10

Both the rich (You who ride) and the poor (who walk) were to listen and share the song. It would have a spiritual and social impact as it spread.

Judges 5:11

the voices of the singers at the watering places: The picture shows divine stories being told where people gathered. Much of the Old Testament stories and psalms likely formed this way. Remembering through song and poetry is essential to both Jewish and Christian worship.

Judges 5:13

Barak's small army marched against the powerful warriors of Sisera's army.

Judges 5:14–18

- These verses honor those who volunteered and shame those who did not.
- Ephraim, Benjamin, and Manasseh (represented by Makir) came from the south. Issachar, where the battle took place, was joined by Zebulun and Naphtali, the two tribes closest to Barak's home base.
- The tribes that were too hesitant and fearful to join the fight included Reuben, Gad (represented by Gilead), Dan, and Asher.

Judges 5:19

Taanach was southeast of Megiddo, a major administrative center. The battle occurred in the lower Jezreel Valley. The mentions of Taanach and Megiddo are likely poetic references to famous places in the Jezreel Valley, not precise battle sites. The fighting likely happened between Mount Tabor and the lowlands near the Kishon River.

Judges 5:19–23

The battle is described. The brave warriors who followed Deborah and Barak became less important as the Lord called upon the stars of heaven and the Kishon River to destroy Sisera's army.

Judges 5:23

The location of Meroz is unknown. Do not confuse it with Merom (Joshua 11:5), which was about twenty miles north in the hills of Galilee.

Judges 5:24–27

The story of Sisera's end includes a short celebration of Jael.

Judges 5:28

Sisera's mother started to lose her natural confidence.

Judges 5:29–30

- The wise women revealed Sisera's evil plans while trying to comfort his mother.
- The poet did not need to explain how the story ended.

Judges 5:31

- Sisera represents the Lord's enemies, while Jael symbolizes those who love the Lord.
- the land had rest: Rest followed the Lord's rescue.

Judges 6:1–6

- After forty years of peace, religious blending caused political instability, and roaming nomads forced the Israelites to live as fugitives.
- The Midianites, once thought to be purely nomadic and based in northwest Arabia, are now known to have built cities and, for a time, controlled much of the Arabian Peninsula and southern Transjordan (the area east of the Jordan). They are joined by the Amalekites (who were earlier part of a Moabite coalition; see study note on Judges 3:12–13) and the mysterious people of the east (compare 1 Kings 4:30; Ezekiel 25:4, 10). The attacks were seasonal but very destructive.

Judges 6:1–8.35

Gideon's time as a judge ends the first era of judges.

Judges 6:5

Camels, known since around 3000 BC, are often linked to eastern nomads and their raids. This might be one of the earliest records of camels in a large military force.

Judges 6:8–10

This unnamed prophet and Deborah are the only prophets mentioned in Judges. This prophet criticized Israel's abandonment of faith using language similar to that in Deuteronomy and later texts.

Judges 6:11–32

Gideon met the angel of the Lord and became a hero. He destroyed the mixed Baal religion of his family and town. He then called his people to fight for the Lord.

Judges 6:12

- might man of valor translates a Hebrew term that is also translated as "strong warriors" (Joshua 6:2), highlighting Gideon's potential as a military hero. It is also translated as "the rich" (2 Kings 15:20), indicating his high social status as part of a leading family.
- The LORD is with you: When God commissions someone to fight, he usually assures them of his presence (see Deuteronomy 1:30; Joshua 1:1–9).

Judges 6:13–15

Like other prophets or judges, Gideon hesitated to obey. He doubted God's presence and his own ability (see study note on Judges 4:8; Exodus 3:1–4:17; Jeremiah 1:4–19).

Judges 6:15

Gideon's personal and clan status was not enough to gather troops.

Judges 6:22

Encounters with divine holiness are naturally dangerous (compare Genesis 32:30; Deuteronomy 5:4–5).

Judges 6:24

The altar, with its symbolic name, honors the divine presence and favor. By the time the account was recorded, the altar likely became a pilgrimage site.

Judges 6:25

In Canaanite worship, Baal was a god of storms and fertility, and Asherah was often shown as a sacred tree.

Judges 6:25–32

In an act commanded by God, Gideon destroyed a community altar to Baal and its Asherah pole.

Judges 6:31

Gideon's father, Joash, was the first to follow Gideon's leadership. He left Baal for the Lord, even though he was the keeper of the Baal shrine.

Judges 6:33

The nomadic coalition (Judges 6:1–6) camped at the eastern end of the Jezreel Valley. This valley separated Israel's central tribes from the Galilean hills.

Judges 6:34

As with other inspired leaders in Judges, the spirit gave Gideon power. Paul often uses a similar metaphor in his letters (for example, Romans 13:12; Galatians 3:27; Ephesians 4:24; 6:11; Colossians 3:10, 12, 14).

Judges 6:36–40

The fleece incident did not confirm God's plan to use Gideon, as that was already clear Judges 6:17–24. Instead, it showed God's patience with Gideon's doubts.

Judges 7:1

The spring of Harod and the hill of Moreh were east of the town of Jezreel. They protected the pass linking the valley of Jezreel to the Jordan River crossings near Beth-shan. Gideon's army was on the north slope of Mount Gilboa. The Midianite forces were in the valley below, with the hill behind them.

Judges 7:2

The Lord does not need a large army to save his people (compare 1 Samuel 14:6). A large army might have hindered success because surprise was crucial to the Lord's plan. Gideon reduced the army to keep humility, not for military strategy.

Judges 7:3

The first reduction identified those who were initially enthusiastic but later reconsidered.

Judges 7:4–8

The Lord chose those who drank from their hands instead of those who knelt. This choice seemed random, but it helped reduce the army's size.

Judges 7:8

The men would use the jars and trumpets borrowed from the warriors sent home in the upcoming battle.

Judges 7:10–15

The Lord gave Gideon a third sign to encourage him (Judges 6:17–21, 36–40).

Judges 7:11

Since the enemy camp was spread out across the valley (Judges 7:1, 12), Gideon and his servant could easily sneak in without being seen.

Judges 7:13–14

People in Egypt and Babylonia often talked about dreams and their meanings. The Old Testament says God inspires dreams, and they are best understood through his guidance (see Genesis 41:15–16, 25; Daniel 2:28). The message of this dream is clear: Gideon's group, symbolized by a round loaf of barley bread, would roll down and defeat the Midianite camp.

Judges 7:16

Splitting the small band into three groups made it seem like a much larger force.

Judges 7:17–20

Surprise and trickery replaced the need for a large army. The war cry, the sudden sound of 300 trumpets, and the torches lighting up made it seem like there was a big army.

Judges 7:21

- The warriors stayed in place while God fought the battle (compare Exodus 14:13; 1 Samuel 12:16; Revelation 19:11–16).
- The Midianites' camels (Judges 6:5) might have caused panic. Camels usually gave a military advantage, but here they were a problem. They were likely tied up for the night, and camels can panic easily.

Judges 7:22

The fugitives ran southeast, past Beth-shan, toward the Jordan River crossings, seeking safer and friendlier places.

Judges 7:24

The shallow crossings of the Jordan River were crucial for stopping an army from escaping (compare Judges 3:28; 12:4–6).

Judges 7:25

Oreb, meaning "raven," and Zeeb, meaning "wolf," were military leaders. In contrast, Zebah and Zalmunna were kings (Judges 8:5). The places where Oreb and Zeeb were captured were later named after them, marking the event.

Judges 8:1–3

Ephraim, the leading tribe of the north-central hill country, produced only a minor judge named Tola (Judges 10:1). The Ephraimites felt left out of the battle because they wanted a share of the spoils. When called, they completed the task. Gideon responded with grace and humility, calming Ephraim's anger (see Proverbs 15:1; compare with Jephthah, Judges 12:1–4). The victories of Gideon and Ephraim over Oreb and Zeeb and their armies became legendary (compare Psalm 83:11–12; Isaiah 10:26).

Judges 8:4–12

- At this point, Gideon seemed as focused on revenge as on victory. His earlier conversations with the Lord suddenly stopped. The group of 300 men made a final attack on the Midianites.
- Gideon chased the fleeing Midianite kings through the Jabbok gorge and then south toward Rabbah, following the caravan route onto the Transjordan plateau.
- Succoth and Peniel were Israelite cities, but their loyalty to Gideon, a new general, was weak. The tribes east of the Jordan were often under Midianite pressure and seemed to fear them.

Judges 8:7

In the ancient Near East, people often tore the flesh of a defeated enemy (compare Amos 1:3; Micah 4:13).

Judges 8:8–9

this tower: Towers were common during this time. Archaeologists have found them at both Succoth and Shechem (see Judges 9:46–49).

Judges 8:10–12

The Midianite remnant, along with its two kings, felt safe after reaching the Transjordan plateau on their way to the desert. This location was far from typical Israelite territory. As before (Judges 7:19–22), Gideon surprised the Midianite army. He captured the two kings and defeated the army, removing the threat of Midianite revenge feared by the leaders of Succoth and Peniel.

Judges 8:13–17

- The return journey likely followed a straight path through the unknown Ascent of Heres, unlike the circular route needed for the ambush.
- The fact that a typical young man from Succoth could write down the names shows that the new alphabetic writing system had become established in Israel.
- Gideon's practice of retribution and execution was common in his time. However, his reputation as the Lord's servant was better supported by his skillful diplomacy (Judges 8:1–3) than by harsh punishment.

Judges 8:18–21

The timing of the slaughter at Tabor is unclear; it might have happened during an earlier battle.

Judges 8:20–21

Honor was very important in this interaction. Being killed by a woman or a child was seen as shameful (Judges 5:24–27; 9:54).

Judges 8:21

crescent ornaments (headbands and crescents in Isaiah 3:18): These were common among desert nomads. Jewelry was a lightweight means of carrying wealth.

Judges 8:24

Both Ishmaelites and Midianites descended from Abraham (Genesis 16:15; 25:2).

Judges 8:27

An ephod was usually part of the priest's clothing (Exodus 28:6–30). Samuel and David also wore one (1 Samuel 2:18; 2 Samuel 6:14; 1 Chronicles 15:27). However, in Judges 17:5 and 18:14–18, the ephod seems to have been a gold image, which became an idol.

Judges 8:28

When there was peace in the land (see study note on Judges 3:7–11) before Abimelech, it lasted for periods of twenty years (3:11, 30; 5:31). After Gideon, these periods became shorter. Israel's ongoing disobedience led to more social instability (compare Judges 17–21).

Judges 8:29–32

Old age usually shows divine blessing, but Gideon's spiritual blessing and leadership declined.

Judges 8:31

concubine: Refer to the study note on Judges 19:1.

Judges 8:33–35

- Gideon's ephod (Judges 8:27) quickly became part of a pagan shrine honoring images of the Canaanite god Baal, here called Baal-berith ("Baal of the covenant"). This sinful act involved forgetting the Lord and his works and being disloyal to godly leadership. Remembering is essential to biblical, covenantal worship, from the time of the exodus (Exodus 12:14, 24) to the ongoing Christian celebration of the Lord's Supper (1 Corinthians 11:25).
- kindness: See study note on Judges 1:24.

Judges 9:1–3

- Abimelech, the son of a concubine (Judges 8:31; see study note on Judges 19:1), claimed he could create the royal dynasty that his father had rejected.
- The absence of any record of a conquest of Shechem, despite Israel's covenant activities in the city (Joshua 24), suggests that Shechem's people became part of Israel. Abimelech's uncles and his mother might have been of non-Israelite origin.

Judges 9:1–57

Abimelech's reign marked a shift from the relative peace of the early judges (Judges 3:7–8:35) to the decline of the later years (10:1–16:31).

Judges 9:3–5

Abimelech asked for money from the local temple of Baal-berith, a worship center for a mixed Canaanite-Israelite religious group.

Judges 9:4

True leaders earn loyalty and appeal to the noble in society, not to reckless troublemakers like Abimelech's hired followers.

Judges 9:5

- The murder of the seventy sons of Gideon on one stone was likely a ritual killing.
- the youngest son…survived: Compare with 2 Kings 11:1–3.

Judges 9:6

Beth-millo, meaning "house of filling," was likely a raised platform for a tower or inner keep (see 2 Samuel 5:9; 1 Kings 9:15, 24). The irony is strong: Abimelech, lacking divine approval, priestly blessing, and public support, met at the "house of filling." His rule was fake.

Judges 9:7

Mount Gerizim was the mountain of blessing, opposite Mount Ebal, the mountain of cursing (Deuteronomy 11:29). Gerizim, located just south of Shechem, served as a natural stage for Jotham's speech and allowed him to escape afterward.

Judges 9:7–21

Jotham shared a fable, where plants and animals act like humans, to illustrate the situation (Judges 9:7–15). He then cursed Abimelech and the leaders of Shechem (Judges 9:16–21). If they had acted dishonestly, it would become clear (Judges 9:56–57).

Judges 9:8–13

- Olives, figs, and grapes were essential to Canaan's agriculture. They provided important crops and enhanced the landscape's beauty.
- To wave back and forth over the trees meant being visible and active but achieving nothing.

Judges 9:14–15

- The trees, preferring a bad king to having none (compare 1 Samuel 8:18–19), asked the thornbush to be king. Although neither useful nor attractive, the thornbush accepted. The person who agreed to be king had no better work to do.
- The thornbush could not provide shade from the hot Middle Eastern sun. Accepting this offer was both pointless and unwise.

Judges 9:16–18

The people of Shechem chose to follow an unworthy man. They also acted dishonestly by plotting with Abimelech against Gideon's family.

Judges 9:19–20

The Shechemites were asked to decide if their actions deserved blessing or cursing. It implied they acted in bad faith, leading to mutual destruction with Abimelech. The Lord is a consuming fire (Hebrews 12:29), and those who act unfaithfully show his justice.

Judges 9:22–23

It took three years to fulfill what God had planned. The spirit that caused trouble found people ready to listen. Those punished for their foolishness actively contributed to their downfall; they caused it themselves.

Judges 9:22–25

As predicted in the story (Judges 9:8–15), Abimelech could not meet the Shechemites' expectations, so they plotted against him.

Judges 9:22–57

Theological statements in Judges 9:23–24 and 9:56–57 frame the story of the civil conflict that caused the destruction of Abimelech and Shechem. This event fulfilled the curse that Jotham declared (Judges 9:19–20).

Judges 9:25

An informer stopped the plot against Abimelech, but society was getting worse as God's curse unfolded.

Judges 9:26–41

Gaal, son of Ebed (meaning "vile son of a slave"), led a failed rebellion against Abimelech. Many citizens of Shechem died in this event. This partially fulfilled Jotham's curse (Judges 9:20).

Judges 9:27–29

People were unhappy with Abimelech, and there was social unrest. With plenty of wine and careless talk, Gaal easily gained initial support.

Judges 9:28

- Who is Abimelech, and who is Shechem: Gaal focused on Abimelech's lineage through his father, Gideon, who was not from Shechem, rather than through his mother (Judges 8:31; 9:2).
- serve the men of Hamor: Gaal's lineage apparently traced back to Hamor, the founder of Shechem (Genesis 33:18–34:31).

Judges 9:30–41

The second plot, like the first (Judges 9:22–25), was stopped by an informer, likely an official appointed by the absent Abimelech. Zebul suggested a bold morning ambush, planning to lure Gaal and his followers into the open country for a confrontation. The plan succeeded. Due to his boasting and possibly Zebul's mocking challenge, Gaal and his men ventured out, only to be driven from town by the loyal Zebul, who acted to cleanse the city.

Judges 9:42

The New Living Translation provides the words "to battle," suggesting that the Shechemites went into the fields to prevent Abimelech from regaining control.

Others believe the Shechemites returned to the fields to continue the harvest (Judges 9:27), thinking Abimelech would be content now that Gaal was expelled.

Judges 9:43–45

Abimelech lost any right to be seen as an inspired leader. He ordered his men to attack the people of Shechem, killing them all and destroying the city.

Judges 9:45

Scattering salt stopped plants from growing and caused destruction.

Judges 9:46–49

The leaders (literally lords) of Shechem, who first plotted against Abimelech, gathered in the temple of Baal-berith. The temple then burned around them. Archaeologists have confirmed this destruction at the site.

Judges 9:48

Mount Zalmon is likely another name for Mount Ebal. It is the mountain opposite Gerizim and near Shechem.

Judges 9:50

Thebez was a fortress located a few miles northeast of Shechem. Abimelech was likely trying to take back Thebez, but he might have been attempting to capture it for the first time.

Judges 9:53

Women often ground grain using a stationary lower millstone. They turned a lighter upper millstone by hand. This method is mentioned in the story of David's murder of Uriah (2 Samuel 11:21).

Judges 9:54–55

It was considered shameful to die at the hands of a woman or a child (see study note on Judges 8:20–21). Abimelech did not receive a peace agreement or burial notice because his rule was not legitimate.

Judges 9:56–57

The theological summary revisits Jotham's fable (Judges 9:24). Abimelech lacked divine charisma, and his death due to divine vengeance brought justice to Gideon's family. Israel's attempt at kingship without divine guidance showed the dangers of leadership not from God.

Judges 10:1

Tola was the first of five minor judges, but little is known about him. Among the five, only Tola was said to save Israel. He came after Abimelech died, when Israel needed help, though not from a foreign enemy.

Judges 10:1–5

Each of the five minor judges (see also Isaiah 12:8–15) led Israel for a set number of years. During this time after Gideon, the phrase the land had rest for forty years (Judges 3:11, 30; 5:31; 8:28) does not appear again. The details about these mysterious figures include their birthplaces and burial sites, and sometimes a brief family history or notable family traits. Four of the five names are found in other family records:

- Tola and Puah are clans of Issachar (Genesis 46:13; Numbers 26:23)
- Elon is a descendant of Zebulun (Genesis 46:14; Numbers 26:26)
- Jair is mentioned in several places (see Numbers 32:41; Deuteronomy 3:14; Joshua 13:30; 1 Kings 4:13)

The absence of specific military achievements and the frequent mention of "judging" suggest they had administrative or judicial roles.

Judges 10:3–4

Jair was likely a descendant of an earlier Jair from the tribe of Manasseh (see Numbers 32:41; Deuteronomy 3:14; compare 1 Kings 4:13). The Towns of Jair, which Jair and his sons controlled, were conquered by the earlier Jair.

Judges 10:6

And again the Israelites did evil…they forsook the LORD: This time, their turning away was more complete than before. They worshiped Baal, Ashtoreth, and other local gods.

Judges 10:6–16

The Lord responded to his people's complete abandonment by allowing severe oppression (Judges 10:8). As usual, Israel called out to the Lord for help (Judges 10:10) only after facing great hardship (10:9). Normally, Israel's cry led to divine help, but God's choice to leave them to their chosen gods marks a change in the cycle described in Judges 2:10–19. Only when the Israelites put aside their foreign gods and served the Lord did he act to save them again (Judges 10:17–11:33).

Judges 10:7–8

- the Philistines: See study notes on Judges 3:3 and 13:1.
- The Ammonites lived east of the Jordan River (see study note on Judges 3:12–13). They started by oppressing the Israelite tribes in Transjordan and then attacked the tribes west of the Jordan River as well.

Judges 10:17–18

The story goes back to the Ammonite oppression, setting the stage for Jephthah's tale.

Judges 10:18

The leaders of Gilead, desperate for guidance, did not ask the Lord (compare Judges 1:1; 20:18). They decided that whoever volunteered to lead would become the ruler of Gilead.

Judges 11:1–2

mighty man of valor: Jephthah had military skill and possibly social importance (see study note on Judges 6:12, where mighty man of valor is translated as "mighty hero"). Gilead was a descendant of Manasseh (Numbers 26:29–33; 32:39–40; 1 Chronicles 7:14–17). Jephthah's social standing made him noticeable, despite the shame of his mother being a prostitute. His half-brothers were not required to accept Jephthah's status or leadership.

Judges 11:1–3

Jephthah's leadership marked a change. He came from humble beginnings, gained followers, spoke well in debates, and had strong military skills. However, his hasty vow (Judges 11:30–31, 34–35) and his stubborn civil war with Ephraim (12:1–6) overshadowed these qualities. Even his victory lasted only six years (Judges 12:7). This period of decline increased the need for a king.

Judges 11:3

Jephthah's worthless men remind us of Abimelech's worthless and reckless men (see Judges 9:4), but Jephthah did not need to buy their loyalty.

Judges 11:4

Ammonites fought: See Judges 10:17.

Judges 11:5–6

These elders were different from Jephthah's brothers, although Jephthah's initial response (Judges 11:7) seems to treat them as the same group. They had promised (Judges 10:18) that whoever led the attack against the Ammonites would become the ruler. Here, in typical Middle Eastern bargaining style, they only offered the position of commander, trying to reduce their initial promise.

Judges 11:7–8

When Jephthah questioned the offer, the elders insisted on using the stronger term, ruler.

Judges 11:9–10

Jephthah confirmed that the elders were offering him the role of ruler, not just as a commander.

Judges 11:11

- At the end of the negotiations, Jephthah became both ruler and commander.
- This Mizpah (meaning "watchtower,") was a shrine east of the Jordan in Gilead, Jephthah's home (Judges 10:17; 11:29, 34). Do not confuse it with Mizpah in Benjamin, near Bethel, where the tribes later gathered and swore oaths for the final battle of Judges (Judges 20:1; 21:1).
- The ceremony at Mizpah, in the presence of the Lord, seems to have been a suzerain-vassal covenant. In this agreement, a ruler (the suzerain) promises to protect and defend a vassal people in exchange for authority over them (see study note on Exodus 20:1–23:33; see also Deuteronomy Book Introduction, "Literary Form").

Judges 11:12–28

- Jephthah first tried to solve the issue through diplomacy instead of using military force (compare Deuteronomy 20:10–11).
- Unlike the nomadic and raiding Midianites from Gideon's time, the Ammonites were a settled tribe. Their land was east of Israel's territory in Transjordan (east of the Jordan River), with Rabbah as their capital. The Ammonites, like the Moabites (both who were descended from Lot) and the Edomites (descendants of Esau), were to be left alone because the Lord assigned their territories to them (Deuteronomy 2:16–23).
- Contrary to the Ammonite king's claim, the Amorites, not the Ammonites or Moabites, lived between the Arnon and Jabbok rivers during the conquest. When Sihon refused to let Israel pass, the Lord gave the land of the Amorite kings Sihon and Og to Israel. The Ammonite king had no valid reason to argue with Israel.

Judges 11:17

Kadesh served as Israel's base for exploring the land (Numbers 32:8; Deuteronomy 1:19; 2:14). The name comes from the Hebrew root "qadesh," meaning "holy," and likely refers to a shrine.

Judges 11:24

Chemosh was the god of the Moabites. If the land east of the Jordan, occupied by Israel, originally belonged to Moab (see study note on Judges 11:25), the Ammonite king would have still seen Chemosh as the god of that land. It is unclear whether Jephthah saw Chemosh as a god or was simply respecting the king's beliefs.

Judges 11:25

Moab and Ammon were related as descendants of Lot. Moab might have had a legitimate claim to the land north of the Arnon, which Israel occupied. Sihon, king of the Amorites, had taken this land from Moab earlier (Numbers 21:24). The Israelites conquered Sihon and took over the disputed territory, but Moab did not try to reclaim it. Ammon should not have claimed it either, because the land had never belonged to them.

Judges 11:26

Whether the conquest and settlement happened in the 1400s BC or the 1200s BC (see Judges Book Introduction, "Chronology of the Judges Era"), Jephthah's 300 years is likely an estimate.

Judges 11:27

Jephthah asked the Lord, the great judge, to decide between Israel and Ammon. The Lord's response in verses Judges 11:29–33 was his answer.

Judges 11:29–31

The spirit of the Lord, a clear sign of divine authority, came upon Jephthah. He traveled through the tribal lands of Gilead and Manasseh, including his hometown of Mizpah in Gilead, to gather troops. Before the battle, he made his well-known vow.

Judges 11:31

The Lord never requires bargaining for his favor. People made vows in different situations, often giving gifts to the Lord in gratitude for his help (compare Genesis 28:20–22). Before battles, people usually offered priestly sacrifices (1 Samuel 13:8–12). Jephthah's vow risked making someone in his household a human sacrifice, which Israelite law strictly forbids (Deuteronomy 18:10).

Judges 11:32

There is no link between the victory, which was a gift from the Lord, and Jephthah's promise.

Judges 11:35

Jephthah made a hasty promise and then blamed his daughter for the outcome. He did not consider the guidance of Scripture. Vows were usually unbreakable (Numbers 30:2), but the Old Testament allows exceptions for unwise vows (Numbers 30:6–8). Since the law forbade human sacrifice, he could have offered a substitute (Leviticus 27:1–8). Jephthah likely did not know these laws, possibly due to his upbringing far from Israel's main centers.

Judges 11:39

Jephthah fulfilled his vow by sacrificing his daughter. There is no proof he only kept her celibate (compare Judges 11:37). Jephthah's foolishness shows how much Israel's society had fallen into lawlessness and turning away from their faith.

Judges 12:1

Zaphon was just east of the Jordan River, opposite the area belonging to the tribe of Ephraim.

Judges 12:1–6

Ephraim felt neglected again (see Judges 8:1–3) and wanted revenge. Unlike Gideon's approach, Jephthah blamed Ephraim, leading to a civil war.

Judges 12:2

There is no record of Jephthah's earlier request.

Judges 12:4

The reason the people of Ephraim taunted the men of Gilead is unclear. They might have resented or looked down on the Israelites living east of the Jordan River.

Judges 12:5

You could only cross the Jordan River at shallow spots where tributaries left silt. This was likely true where the Jabbok joined the Jordan.

Judges 12:6

- The term Shibboleth is now used to mean any password used to identify imposters. Armies have used such linguistic tests throughout history.
- 42,000 Ephraimites: This number might also mean "42 troops" (see study note on Exodus 12:37).

Judges 12:7

six years: Like all the judges after Gideon, Jephthah served for a specific and short time (see study note on Judges 8:28). Jephthah received an honorable burial, showing that despite his limitations, he was an inspired and successful warrior (Judges 11:29; contrast with Abimelech, study note on Judges 9:54–55).

Judges 12:8

If this was the northern Bethlehem in Zebulun, it fits the structure of Judges. Each tribe provides one of the twelve judges (see Judges Book Introduction, "Summary").

Judges 12:8–15

The account continues with these lesser judges (see study note on Judges 10:1–5).

Judges 12:15

The Amalekites had previously lived in parts of Ephraim (Judges 5:14).

Judges 13:1

The Philistines, mentioned earlier (Judges 3:3; 10:7), were newcomers to Canaan, later called Palestine. This warlike group of sea people had Greek, not Canaanite, roots. They settled in the southwestern coastal areas around 1200 BC. From then on, Philistia became Israel's natural enemy and increasingly threatened its national existence. Israel developed institutions like kingship partly to respond to the Philistine threat.

Judges 13:1–16.31

Samson, who gets more attention in the book of Judges than any other judge, is more mysterious than Jephthah. Samson shows great inspiration as a leader. He also represents the unstoppable move toward chaos, which shows the need for a more organized society under a godly ruler.

Judges 13:2

- Before migrating to the far north (Judges 18), the tribe of Dan tried to settle in Israel's southwest (Joshua 19:40–48). This led to direct conflict with the incoming Philistines.
- Zorah was west of Judah, in the area newly occupied by the Philistines. Both Dan and neighboring Judah submitted to Philistine control (Judges 14:4; 15:11).

Judges 13:3–5

Manoah's wife was promised a son who would be dedicated as a Nazirite from birth (see Numbers 6:1–21; compare 1 Samuel 1:11). Samson's uncut hair would play a key role in his story.

Judges 13:4

anything unclean: See Leviticus 11.

Judges 13:6–7

In the Bible, angels often appeared to women who could not have children (Judges 13:2). They announced that God would help them have a child (see Luke 1:5–25; compare Genesis 18; 1 Samuel 1).

Judges 13:12–13

Considering Judges 13:4–5, Manoah's question might seem repetitive. However, Judges 13:8 shows that Manoah felt a strong personal duty to raise the child. The angel responded kindly but emphasized the wife's responsibility. This explains why the angel first approached her, not Manoah.

Judges 13:15–16

Manoah would only let a visitor leave after offering a meal, following eastern hospitality customs. The angel insisted that any food be given as a sacrifice to the Lord. This, along with his reluctance to eat (compare with Gideon's visitor, Judges 6:17–22), suggests this was a theophany (an appearance of God). Until then, Manoah had not recognized his visitor's divine nature.

Judges 13:17–18

The Lord's name is a divine secret (Genesis 32:29; Exodus 3:13–14). God knows our names, but we use words of wonder and adoration to address him. The true essence of the infinite cannot be fully expressed or understood by the finite.

Judges 13:19–22

Humans cannot fully experience God's holy presence and survive (see Judges 6:20–24; Exodus 19:21; 33:20). The Old Testament often describes God appearing on earth in human form. These appearances point forward to God's full and final appearance on earth in the incarnation of Jesus.

Judges 13:25

- Inspired leaders are filled with the divine spirit. Despite Samson's obvious failures, the spirit worked powerfully in him.
- Mahaneh-dan (literally "camp of Dan") is mentioned again in Judges 18:12. The phrase might describe a temporary settlement rather than a fixed location.
- Zorah (Judges 13:2) and Eshtaol were in the valley of Sorek, about fifteen miles west of Jerusalem at the pass leading down to Philistine territory.

Judges 14:1

Timnah was likely about four miles down the Sorek Valley from Mahaneh-dan, where Israelite and Philistine territories met.

Judges 14:1–15.20

Samson's decision to marry a Philistine woman was the Lord's way (Judges 14:4) of starting to address the Philistine threat (see 13:5). One event led to another, marked by three times when the Spirit came strongly upon him (Judges 14:6, 19; 15:14). During these events, Samson was a strong but imperfect hero.

Judges 14:2

Samson chose his bride based solely on her looks. Marrying outside the covenant was a major sign of unfaithfulness (Joshua 23:12–13), but God can still work through human mistakes.

Judges 14:3

The term pagan (uncircumcised) was often used for Philistines. Unlike many Middle Eastern nations, they did not practice circumcision.

Judges 14:5–6

The spirit first empowered Samson when a lion attacked him (compare Judges 13:25).

Judges 14:11

The reason for thirty companions is unclear (compare 2 Samuel 23:13). Men, a word that usually means "friends," might add irony here (Judges 14:12–20).

Judges 14:12

Riddles were common tests of skill or a form of entertainment that often used double meanings. Although there is some evidence of bees building hives in dead animals, solving the mystery required knowing what Samson knew.

Judges 14:14–19

Israel's hero, like Sisera, was defeated by a woman (Judges 4:21; see study note on Judges 8:20–21).

Judges 14:18

People often answered a riddle with another riddle. In this case, the Philistines used a similar poetic couplet. They did not reveal everything they knew; they just wanted to win the contest.

Judges 14:19

Samson kept his part of the agreement (compare 1 Samuel 18:20–27). He went home without completing his marriage, which usually happened after the seven-day feast.

Judges 14:20

According to some ancient customs, giving the bride to the best man was forbidden, even if the marriage was not completed. The father's action seems to have been deceitful (compare Judges 15:2–3, 6).

Judges 15:1

The wheat harvest occurred at the end of May. We do not know how long this was after the wedding feast. Sometimes, a bride stayed with her parents for a few months before moving to the groom's home. During this time, the couple could have conjugal visits.

Judges 15:2

The father might have believed his daughter was abandoned (see study note on Judges 14:20). Offering the younger sister could have been his way to fix his betrayal.

Judges 15:3–5

In revenge, Samson destroyed the grain harvest, vineyards, and olive groves.

Judges 15:6–10

The cycle of revenge was complex (see Judges 9:7–21). First, Samson sought revenge on the Philistine community, not his in-laws. Then, the Philistines recognized Samson as a victim of injustice (see study note on Judges 14:20) and retaliated against his in-laws. This prompted Samson to avenge his in-laws by attacking the Philistines. This series of events nearly led to a war with Israel. God was starting to rescue Israel through Samson (Judges 13:5; see 1 Samuel 7:3).

Judges 15:11

The tribe of Judah missed a chance to end Philistine rule. They seemed willing to live under foreign control. We can only imagine what might have happened if the Judeans had fully followed the Lord's covenant, which instructed them to take the land and drive out its inhabitants (see study note on Judges 1:1).

Judges 15:12

Swear to me that you will not kill me yourselves: Samson's superhuman abilities might have only worked against Israel's enemies. He broke these ropes only after the spirit of the Lord came upon him (Judges 15:14).

Judges 15:13

New ropes were stronger, more flexible, and less likely to break than older ones.

Judges 15:14–15

Samson and the Judeans were content with this small victory and did not try to end Philistine rule. This shows Israel's decreasing trust in God's promises.

Judges 15:16

- Like other warrior-heroes such as Moses, Deborah, and David, Samson celebrated his victory with poetry. He used a short couplet that combined colorful speech with wordplay. The Hebrew word "lekhi" means both "Lehi" (Judges 15:9) and "jawbone." Similarly, "heaps" and "donkey" share the Hebrew word "khamor."
- piled them into heaps: Or made donkeys of them.

Judges 15:18

Samson called out to the Lord because he was afraid of dying from thirst and being captured by the defeated pagans (the uncircumcised; see study note on Judges 14:3). Samson prayed deeply and passionately twice: once when he feared an attack and once when he was attacking others (Judges 16:28–30).

Judges 15:20

This summary formula is repeated in Judges 16:31. Its presence here shows that Samson's time as a judge was effectively over (compare Judges 10:2, 3; 12:7). He had done little more than demonstrate Israel's potential for rescue; the Philistines still controlled the land.

Judges 16:1–31

This last chapter of Samson's complicated history does not involve his role as a judge. Samson abandoned his calling and eventually lost his gifts. Only in his final encounter, when he prayed to the Lord again, did he regain any of his heroic stature.

Judges 16:2–3

During that time, city gates were locked at night to stop anyone from entering or leaving. The men of the city, seeing the gates locked, likely slept in a gatehouse. They planned to continue their watch in the morning.

Judges 16:3

Samson lifted the entire gate system, which was six to twelve feet wide, and carried it to the hills across from Hebron, a town about forty miles away. Samson embarrassed the Philistines but did not defeat them.

Judges 16:4–22

Samson's downfall and defeat by Delilah, the temptress, is a universally appealing tragedy.

Judges 16:5

The Philistine leaders knew they could not defeat Samson directly, so they used deceit. The generous offer from the leaders (lords) of the five Philistine cities (Judges 3:3) shows how seriously they took this issue.

Judges 16:6

Delilah seemed more interested in silver than in self-preservation (see Judges 14:15). She apparently did not return Samson's love.

Judges 16:7

People often made bowstrings from dried animal tendons or gut. The number seven was symbolic, possibly linked to the Philistines' belief in magic. Samson appears more comfortable in Philistine culture than in following his Israelite vows as a Nazirite.

Judges 16:11

They had already tested brand-new ropes (Judges 15:13–14).

Judges 16:13–14

Samson's hair might have been woven into the fabric as the weft on the loom's warp, then tightened like in regular weaving.

Judges 16:16

Samson should have seen the danger (compare Judges 14:17), but his spiritual blindness caused mental exhaustion.

Judges 16:17–19

Samson's hair symbolized his promise to the Lord. Cutting his hair would break this promise. The seven braided locks were just a symbol; the Lord's presence was the true source of his strength.

Judges 16:18

After being tricked three times, the rulers gave up and left. Now, they returned with money in hand, knowing this was their dream moment.

Judges 16:20

Similar to the regretful but overconfident Israelites from earlier times (Numbers 14:40–45), Samson did not notice his hair was cut and that God's presence had left him (compare Hosea 7:9).

Judges 16:22

No one was sure if the Lord would restore Samson's strength as his hair grew back; there was only hope that the Lord's earlier promise—that Samson would start to rescue Israel—remained true.

Judges 16:23–24

The Philistines celebrated joyfully, giving all the credit to their god, Dagon. They believed a nation's strength showed the power of its gods.

Judges 16:28–30

Samson sought personal revenge, but he also helped fulfill God's plan to rescue his people.

Judges 17:1

- Micah is a shortened name meaning "Who is like the Lord?" It emphasizes the difference between the Lord and a carved image or idol.
- The hill country of Ephraim was a natural gathering place in central Israel (Judges 17:7–8; 18:2, 13; 19:1, 16).

Judges 17:1–21.25

These two epilogues (Judges 17–18 and 19–21) show that inspired but unstructured leadership cannot last. As society moved toward chaos and civil war, the phrase, In those days there was no king in Israel appears four times. The phrase, everyone did what was right in his own eyes is added twice (Judges 17:6; 18:1; 19:1; 21:25). The era of inspired leadership declined and ended in disorder. Something important was missing.

Judges 17:2–3

- Micah's mother was indulgent and worshipped idols, yet she used the Lord's name in both cursing and blessing.
- I heard you place a curse: People believed words in curses and blessings had power, especially if the speaker had authority (compare Genesis 27; Isaiah 55:11).
- eleven hundred shekels: This large amount was also given to Delilah (Judges 16:5). It was likely Micah's mother's life savings or dowry.
- Blessed be my son by the LORD!: Micah's mother hoped the blessing would cancel out her earlier curse.

Judges 17:4–5

We do not know what Micah's mother did with the other 900 shekels. Perhaps she used them to pay for the shrine (literally house of gods).

Judges 17:5

- ephod: See study note on Judges 8:27.
- household idols: Compare Genesis 31:19–32; 2 Kings 23:24; Zechariah 10:2. The Bible criticizes the powerlessness of these personal gods. Micah making his son his personal priest was very unusual: The father was supposed to lead the family's religious activities (Deuteronomy 6:7; Job 1:5), only Aaron's descendants could be priests (Exodus 28:1–29:37; 30:30–33; 40:12–15), and priests served all of Israel, not just one family.

Judges 17:7–8

This Levite does not fit typical biblical categories. Some Levites were priests, while others served in the temple (compare Numbers 3–4). Levites lived throughout Israel (Genesis 49:5–7; Joshua 21). This young man, likely a descendant of Gershom (Judges 18:30; see Exodus 2:21–22), lived in Judah but not in a Levitical town. He was searching for a new place to live.

Judges 17:13

In Micah's view, hiring a priest made the shrine seem more legitimate. However, he believed the Lord would bless him due to superstition, not obedience. Micah's disregard for God's covenant would lead to a curse that no unemployed Levite could prevent. Micah was not the last Israelite to seek a priest or Levite to legit-

imize improper religious practices (compare 1 Kings 12:28–31; 2 Kings 16:10–18).

Judges 18:1–31

The migration of the Danites (compare Joshua 19:40–48) shows the tribe's failure to follow God's covenant and reflects Israel's decline. Micah's personal heresy (Judges 17:4–5) grew into the apostasy of the entire tribe (18:30–31). The initial covenant failure (Judges 17:19–36) led to social breakdown during the time of Jephthah and Samson (Judges 11–16). Eventually, law and order gave way to banditry and pillaging (Judges 18:27–28).

Judges 18:2

Zorah and Eshtaol: Scouts came from the area where the Spirit of the Lord first moved Samson (Judges 13:25). The mention of these two towns reminds us that Samson's mission was unfinished, either by his tribe, Dan, or their powerful neighbor, Judah. Instead of fighting the Lord's battles, these skilled warriors bullied fellow Israelites (Judges 18:24–25) and attacked a defenseless city (18:27; compare Genesis 49:17).

Judges 18:3–4

The Danites either recognized the young Levite's accent (voice), which was from the region of Judah (Judges 17:7), or they knew him personally. Their questions were not just about his credentials; they also sought some divine guidance (Judges 18:5). His reply (Judges 18:6) showed he was willing to be a mercenary priest.

Judges 18:5–6

The Lord had promised Dan land in the southwest, but they had not taken it (see Judges 1:34; Joshua 19:40–48). Now they sought God's blessing from a hired priest. This priest's "blessing," like Micah's mother's (Judges 17:2), sounded religious but had no basis in Israel's covenant with the Lord.

Judges 18:7

Laish has been thoroughly excavated and was an impressive city at that time. The description of Laish and its connection to the port of Sidon is not entirely clear in the text or historical records. The people of Laish, as Phoenicians, might have expected to be exempt from Israel's attack on the Canaanites. This language is largely repeated in Judges 18:28.

Judges 18:9–10

The language is similar to the report after the mission to explore the land (Numbers 14:7–8; Deuteronomy 1:25), but the context is very different. Joshua and Caleb overcame their fear and acted with faith by remembering the Lord's promise (compare Joshua 2:9, 24; 6:2; 10:19, 30). The Danite warriors asked for God's blessing and saw the land's value, but their overconfidence contrasts with the strong faith of Joshua and Caleb.

Judges 18:12

Kiriath-jearim: This town, located northwest of Jerusalem, housed the Ark for twenty years (1 Samuel 7:1–2) after its return from Philistine captivity. It was on the border of Judah and Benjamin and received a memorial name linked to Dan's wanderings (compare with the different site in Judges 13:25).

Judges 18:14

an ephod, household gods, a graven image, and a molten idol: See study notes on Judges 8:27 and 17:5.

Judges 18:14–26

This dishonest exchange reveals the lack of integrity in everyone involved.

Judges 18:15

The five dishonest scouts ignored the host and went directly to their target, the young and naive Levite who lacked principles.

Judges 18:16

The 600 armed warriors were ready to attack the lone Levite. Unlike Gideon's army of 300, which faced the large Midianite forces (Judges 7:2–11), the Danites were just armed bullies.

Judges 18:18

The priest asked the rhetorical question more to express concern about his own future than to stop the theft (compare Judges 18:20).

Judges 18:19

Using Micah's words to be a father and priest (Judges 17:10), but without his kindness, the Danites' question was pointless with 600 men at the door.

Judges 18:20

The young priest accepted the offer. Ignoring his generous supporter, he helped steal Micah's valuable

items. Micah's mother's blessing (Judges 17:3) was losing its value.

Judges 18:22

Some of Micah's neighbors had joined the religious group at his shrine.

Judges 18:23

The question aimed to intimidate Micah into giving up the fight.

Judges 18:24

Micah's final speech is sad and pitiful. He started by stealing from his mother and ended up losing everything to even worse thieves. The story is full of irony, especially when Micah loses the gods he created. His fate is like that of anyone who abandons the Lord's covenant: he is left with nothing!

Judges 18:25

angry (literally bitter of soul; translated "bitter distress" 1 Samuel 1:10; "discontented," 1 Samuel 22:2; "fierce," 2 Samuel 17:8): This term describes people whose deep disappointment with life makes their actions unpredictable.

Judges 18:28

Beth-rehob might have been an Aramean kingdom to the north (2 Samuel 10:6). The Danite warriors captured this defenseless city without heroism or a holy war. Dan fulfilled Jacob's mixed blessing by abandoning the high calling of governing his people (Genesis 49:16). Instead, they became a snake by the road, a viper in the path that bites the horse's heels so that its rider tumbles backward (Genesis 49:17).

Judges 18:29–31

The city of Dan became the northernmost point of Israel's territory (for example, Judges 20:1; 2 Samuel 3:10; 1 Kings 4:25; 2 Chronicles 30:5). It remained a center of idol worship throughout its history (see 1 Kings 12:28–30; Amos 8:14).

Judges 18:30

- The wandering Levite is now called Jonathan. He was a descendant of Moses through Gershom (Exodus 2:21–22).
- The exile traditionally began with the fall of the northern kingdom in 722 BC. Considering the reference to Shiloh (Judges 18:31), the exile of the Ark from Shiloh (1 Samuel 4–6) might be relevant.

Judges 18:31

- The tribe of Dan continued its religious unfaithfulness at least through the time of the judges. It is not clear if Samuel, Saul, or David corrected this.
- Joshua used Shiloh, a town in the hill country of Ephraim, as his command post and main shrine (Joshua 18:1) during the conquest and distribution of the land (Joshua 18–22). The priest Eli and his sons served the Lord at Shiloh (1 Samuel 1:3). The Philistines likely destroyed the town and sanctuary around 1050 BC (see 1 Samuel 4:1–11). Later, people remembered Shiloh as an example of God's judgment on false worship done in his name (see Jeremiah 7:12–14; 26:6; compare Psalm 78:60).

Judges 19:1

A concubine was a second-class wife. In societies where polygamy was common, people could buy a concubine, acquire one as debt repayment, or take one in war. Sometimes, a concubine was added to compensate for a deficiency in a legitimate wife (for example, Genesis 16:1–4; 30:3–13; 35:22). However, in the case of the Levite, there seems to have been no other wife.

Judges 19:1–21.25

- This second epilogue (see study note on Judges 17:1–21:25) shifts the focus from individuals to entire tribes. It begins with the outrage in the Benjamite town of Gibeah (Judges 19), which led to a civil war (Judges 20) and the near destruction of Benjamin. It then moves to the attempt to save the tribe from disappearing (Judges 21). The book ends with the familiar refrain: In those days there was no king in Israel; everyone did what was right in his own eyes. This was what they did in the days of Gibea, perhaps the lowest point in Israel's history that Hosea, 400 years later, would compare to the depths Ephraim had reached (Hosea 9:9; 10:9).
- The path was cleared for a shift from charismatic leadership to "covenant-charismatic kingship." This kingship combined living under the Lord's covenant with the anointing of the spirit for ruling, as seen with Saul and David.

Judges 19:4

The woman's father showed traditional Near Eastern hospitality, unlike the events that would later happen in Gibeah (Judges 19:14–28). The scene in Bethlehem offers reconciliation and the hope of a fresh start.

Judges 19:5–7

Some suggest the delay in leaving is like Samson's seven-day bridal feast (Judges 14:10–20). However, it may simply show the father's reluctance to say goodbye to his daughter.

Judges 19:10

Jebus: See study note on Judges 1:21. The city kept its old name and foreign status in Israel until David captured it (2 Samuel 5:6–10).

Judges 19:13

The two Benjamite towns, Gibeah and Ramah, hold an important place in Israelite history. They are linked with judges like:

- Deborah (Judges 4:5)
- Priests like Eleazar (Joshua 24:33)
- Prophets like Samuel (1 Samuel 8:4)
- Kings like Saul (1 Samuel 10:26)

Gibeah's noble history makes the tragic events that followed even more significant.

Judges 19:15

The usual hospitality rules in Israel and the Near East required a town citizen to offer shelter (compare Isaiah 58:7; Luke 14:13–14; Romans 12:13; 1 Timothy 3:2; 5:10; Hebrews 13:2; 1 Peter 4:9). The Levite had money and supplies (Judges 19:19), so there was even less reason not to help. This lack of basic kindness shows the social problems during the time of Judges.

Judges 19:16

The old man came from the hill country of Ephraim, not from the territory of Benjamin. The people of Gibeah did not want to help.

Judges 19:18

now I am going to the house of the LORD: The Levite did not mention his status or explain why he was traveling.

Judges 19:20

The old man's urgent response hinted at the trouble to come (see Genesis 19:2–3).

Judges 19:22

wicked men: Hebrew sons of Belial; see study notes on 1 Kings 21:10; 1 Samuel 1:16; 2 Corinthians 6:15. Their goal was to commit homosexual rape. Compare Genesis 19:4–5.

Judges 19:23

this man is a guest in my house: It was shameful to be unkind to a visitor. However, the crowd's evil demands went beyond rudeness. They intended to harm the visitor (see Judges 20:5).

Judges 19:24

The old man tried to uphold the social duty of hospitality, even if it meant putting the vulnerable at risk (compare James 1:27). We cannot lessen the horror of what happened next, whether in their time or ours. The era of the judges was ending in extreme moral decay. Something was seriously wrong.

Judges 19:25

Compare the guidance given to husbands in Ephesians 5:25–28.

Judges 19:28–29

The Levite's actions show the terrible effects of a corrupt culture.

Judges 20:1

This Mizpah was not the one east of the Jordan linked to Jephthah (Judges 10:17; 11:11, 29, 34). It was a place in central Israel. The name means "watchtower."

Judges 20:3

The tribe of Benjamin likely got the message (Judges 19:29), so they knew trouble was coming.

Judges 20:5

- The "wicked men" (Judges 19:22) were important citizens (literally lords).
- They intended to kill me: The Levite believed the men of Gibeah wanted to kill him after they killed his concubine.

Judges 20:9

The lots might have been the Urim and Thummim on the priest's breastplate (Exodus 28:30; compare Joshua 14:2; 1 Samuel 14:41; Ezra 2:63).

Judges 20:12–13

Israel acknowledged corporate responsibility. The leading citizens of Gibeah were guilty (Judges 20:5), and all of Gibeah became involved in their crimes by not disciplining them. The tribe of Benjamin had a responsibility to bring Gibeah to justice; by failing to do so, they all shared the guilt. If Israel had not ad-

dressed Benjamin's wrongdoing, the guilt would have extended to the entire nation.

Judges 20:13–17

Benjamin's response matched its independent and warlike nature (compare Genesis 49:27). The tribe had strong confidence in its famous warriors (Judges 3:12–30; 1 Chronicles 12:2). Although outnumbered nearly three to one, they defeated the rest of Israel twice and caused many casualties (Judges 20:18–24).

Judges 20:16

- left-handeders: See study note on Judges 3:15.
- The sling was like the one David used to kill Goliath (1 Samuel 17:40–51). The slinger placed a stone in a small pouch attached to a leather strap. He swung it around his head to build speed, then released one end to launch the stone. A slinger could attack from a distance, unlike a swordsman.

Judges 20:18

To go first means to lead, but not always to come before (Genesis 49:10).

Judges 20:19–21

The three battles occurred near the city. Despite having more troops and seeking guidance from the Lord, the Israelites were defeated by the defenders on the first day.

Judges 20:22–23

After a period of weeping and likely confession (see Joshua 7), the Israelite troops received divine guidance and regained confidence.

Judges 20:24–25

A second disaster shook the Israelites' confidence (Judges 20:26–28).

Judges 20:26–28

The pressure to admit defeat and return home was growing. The Israelites intensified their activities in the Lord's presence, seeking his guidance.

Judges 20:29–44

On the third day, they used similar tricks and surprise attacks as when they took over Ai (Joshua 8:1–29).

Judges 20:33

Baal-tamar is a town that has not been identified.

Judges 20:36–48

This section provides another description of the battle.

Judges 20:43

overtook them in the vicinity of Gibeah on the east: The geography is complex. There may be confusion between Gibeah and nearby Geba (1 Samuel 13:3–14:5; see also 1 Kings 15:22).

Judges 20:47

the rock of Rimmon: "Rimmon" was a personal name from the tribe of Benjamin (2 Samuel 4:2). The place was about four miles east of Bethel. It was a stronghold, likely a cliff dwelling, that protected fugitives because it was hard to reach.

Judges 21:1

In Judges, for the second time, a foolish vow caused problems for those who made it (see study note on Judges 11:31).

Judges 21:3

The idea of a twelve-tribe league was important in Israel. It lasted despite Levi separating from the other tribes, Simeon and Asher almost disappearing, and Joseph splitting into two tribes (Manasseh and Ephraim). Losing one tribe would have implied that God's agreement with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob was falling apart.

Judges 21:8–9

Jabesh-gilead was an important town east of the Jordan River. Its failure to join the war against Benjamin caused a serious break in unity (see Judges 21:5).

Judges 21:11

Devote to destruction: See Leviticus 27:28–29.

Judges 21:15–17

- The people grieved for Benjamin: Israel worried about the nation's division.
- The gap in Israel was God's doing, as the war against Benjamin was a response to God's covenant.

Judges 21:19

The yearly feast in Shiloh may have originally been a Canaanite celebration.

Judges 21:23

The land given to them was the land assigned to the tribe of Benjamin by the Lord's agreement (Judges 2:6).

Judges 21:24

The people of Israel persevered despite having no inspired leaders (Judges 17–18) and the tribal league's failure (Judges 19–21). Tribes and families remained strong, ensuring Israel and its tribes would endure.

Judges 21:25

The conclusion of Judges 17–21 explains the reason for the social disorder of the time. After the period of the judges, God would establish a new covenant with Israel involving King David (2 Samuel 7) and the promise of a messianic rule. The fulfillment of that promise would exceed anything imaginable during the time when Israel had no king.